

Britain: the suffragettes

Women in the West had begun to feel that they, and by extension those elsewhere, should no longer be regarded as second-class citizens. Extension of the right to vote to increasing numbers of men in countries such as Britain and the United States had left them asking why women should not be entitled to vote. In 1903, Emmeline Pankhurst founded the WSPU with the aim of using militant tactics to further this cause. Its slogan declared "Deeds not words," and the tactics of the suffragettes, as the vote-seeking women were by now mockingly known, became increasingly violent. Chaining themselves to public buildings and the disruption of meetings escalated into the smashing of shop windows, acts of arson, and bombings.

The more active members of the WSPU were repeatedly arrested and imprisoned: Pankhurst received seven prison sentences; Davison, nine. In 1909, the WSPU began to stage hunger strikes in prison; in response they were force-fed—a painful and degrading process.

The US: the suffragists

The experience of what in the US were known as the suffragists had clear parallels. The Women's Christian Temperance Union campaigned peacefully for women's rights,

arguing that women could not influence political decisions—in this case, Prohibition—without having the right to vote.

However, the National Women's Party (NWP), established in 1916, imitated the militant tactics of Britain's WSPU. This was no surprise, given that its founder, Alice Paul, had been a member of the WSPU from 1907 to 1910 and had been sent to prison three times. The NWP's so-called Silent Sentinels, protesting outside the White House from January 1917, were also arrested and force-fed.

Success at last

At the outbreak of World War I, the WSPU stopped campaigning, mobilizing itself instead in support of the war effort. The contribution made by women during the war plainly demonstrated just how much wider their role could be than that traditionally expected of them as wives and mothers. In 1918, all British women aged 30 or over were granted the right to vote. In 1928, suffrage in Britain was extended to women aged 21 or over.

Meanwhile, in the United States, the NWP continued its protest into 1919, when Congress approved the Nineteenth Amendment, which was ratified the following year, granting women the same voting rights as men. ■

Emmeline Pankhurst



The best known of all the suffragettes, Emmeline Pankhurst (1858–1928) epitomized a new breed of politically active

women in the early 20th century. She was born into—and later remained in by marriage—an eminently respectable, somewhat left-leaning, middle-class world in the north of England, which only served to cement her desire to further the cause of women's rights. This decision would prove explosive. She was single-minded, exceptionally active, and wholly unflinching in her refusal to compromise. Her leadership of the WSPU exhibited a determination to take the fight for

women's suffrage into the heart of what she saw as the enemy camp. Her increasing readiness to use more violent methods to secure suffragette goals alienated many who may otherwise have been her natural supporters—women as much as men. Nonetheless, her absolute refusal to back down, coupled with the fervor she inspired in her followers, introduced a new mood of feminist militancy into a complacent masculine political world.